Power from the People:

How Autocrats Use Referendums to Generate Support for Controversial Policies

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Abstract: Why do autocrats put their initiatives to a public vote? Scholars have only recently turned their attention to authoritarian referendums as a "nominally democratic institution." Focusing on "voluntary referendums"—cases when rulers hold a public vote despite not being constitutionally required to do so—we advance two claims: first, that autocrats sometimes stage public votes to proclaim nominal popular approval for controversial policies; and second, that organizing such votes can help generate support for these initiatives. We argue that authoritarian referendums are more than discrete voting moments. Instead, they are complex institutions with important upstream components that rulers can exploit. We illustrate this argument using evidence from the Russian 2020 public vote on constitutional amendments, while also showing its applicability across other autocracies.

Keywords: referendums, authoritarianism, Russia, non-democracy, institutions, dictatorship, constitutions, polling, voting, plebiscites.

Why do autocrats put their initiatives to a public vote? One simple answer is that rulers might be constitutionally required to do so; even in autocracies, constitutions routinely specify that certain political changes must be ratified by citizens. But there are many instances when non-democratic rulers have put their initiatives up for citizens' approval when they are not constitutionally obliged to do so. According to Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) data, voluntary referendums constitute the majority of cases of public votes in authoritarian regimes: fully 60 percent of direct popular votes in non-democracies between 1945 and 2020 were undertaken on the rulership's own initiative.[1]

1 We define a referendum as a state-administered popular vote open to the whole electorate but not used to elect individuals to office. We use "referendum," "direct popular vote," and "public vote" synonymously in this paper. Our focus is on *voluntary referendums*—sometimes referred to as "plebiscites"—which concern "measures [that are] placed on the ballot by the executive and/or the legislature […] for which the constitution

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doi: 10.5129/001041526X17907803781785

In this article, we investigate why an autocrat might willingly choose to put their proposals to a public vote. One prominent example took place in Russia in 2020, when citizens went to the polls to vote on a package of constitutional changes. Notably, this included a change to term limits that would permit Vladimir Putin to remain president until 2036. This public vote was not constitutionally mandated. In explaining his decision to put these changes to the public, Putin claimed it would be an example of the "highest form of democracy," allowing for the expression of the "will of citizens."[2] However, rather than an opportunity for Russian citizens to voice their sincere views, the outcome was widely seen as a foregone conclusion. The president's spokesperson, Dmitry Peskov, even admitted that it was not a "competitive vote."[3] Why bother putting these changes to the people?

The nascent literature on this question suggests that authoritarian referendums are deployed for their repressive effects.[4] According to this logic, rulers put policies to a public vote in order to show the regime's political dominance through incredibly wide margins of victory. Scholars argue that these efforts signal to both real and potential opposition the futility of voicing dissent, dissuading them from launching any challenge to the regime.

We argue that referendums can serve a different purpose for rulers. Specifically, these votes are not just used by autocrats to proclaim the public's nominal support for the ruler's initiatives. They can also be used to generate genuine buy-in for political changes. In making this argument, we emphasize the need to shift focus from conceptualizing referendums as discrete moments at which votes are cast or the results are announced. Instead, we unpack the steps leading up to the vote to show that the overwhelming official victories are not entirely predetermined. The process of announcing, drafting, and publicly discussing the issues put to the people can be used to negotiate with elites and citizens, identify segments of society that might be induced to support the measures, and formulate the most

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or basic laws does [sic] not require a vote" (V-Dem Codebook v15, page 106). These can be distinguished from *obligatory referendums*—sometimes referred to as "constitutional referendums"—in which "measures [are] placed on the ballot by the executive and/or the legislature for which the constitution or basic laws require a vote" (V-Dem Codebook v15, page 106). Michael Coppedge et al., "Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project – Dataset (Version 15)," 2025, https://v-dem.net/data/the-v-dem-dataset/. Regime coding is from Carles Boix, Michael K. Miller, and Sebastian Rosato, "Boix-Miller-Rosato Dichotomous Coding of Democracy, 1800–2020," *Harvard Dataverse*, *V1*, 2022, https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/FENWWR.

2 Associated Press, "Putin Remains Coy on Future Political Plans," *Voice of America*, February 4, 2020, https://www.voanews.com/a/europe_putin-remains-coy-future-political-plans/6183678.html.

3 Polina Khimshiashvili and Georgiy Tadtaev, "Kreml' otvetil na poyavlenie pervykh dannykh ob itogakh golosovaniya [The Kremlin responded to the appearance of the first data on voting results]," *RBK*, June 29, 2020, https://www.rbc.ru/politics/29/06/2020/5ef9b5e39a79470a8c3f9129.

4 Matt Qvortrup, Brendan O'Leary, and Ronald Wintrobe, "Explaining the Paradox of Plebiscites," *Government and Opposition* 55, no. 2 (2020): 202–19, https://doi.org/10.1017/gov.2018.16; Alberto Penadés and Sergio Velasco, "Plebiscites: A Tool for Dictatorship," *European Political Science Review* 14, no. 1 (2022): 74–93, https://doi.org/10.1017/S175577392100031X; Alberto Penadés and Sergio Velasco, "The Effect of Referendums on Autocratic Survival: Running Alone and Not Finishing Second," *Government and Opposition* 59, no. 2 (2024): 405–24, https://doi.org/10.1017/gov.2023.31; Alberto Penadés and Sergio Velasco-Monje, "Authoritarian Personalism, Institutional Constraints, and Plebiscitary Rule," *Acta Politica*, 61 (2026): 252–68, https://doi.org/10.1057/s41269-024-00367-1.

effective wording and strategies for securing a win. These activities create opportunities to identify opponents to the proposals and overcome this opposition, and to construct a manifestly public endorsement of changes proposed by the dictator.

Building on this insight, we suggest that one reason autocrats voluntarily opt to hold referendums is to pass controversial policies and to do so in a way that helps to minimize the risk and scale of public backlash. In our conception, "controversial policies" are those initiatives that are important to the ruler but nonetheless are opposed by at least a significant minority of the population. In these circumstances, autocrats can rarely rely on repression alone to quell dissent. Especially within the contemporary context of hybrid regimes, "sovereign democracy," and "informational autocrats," rulers are expected to be (or, at least, to seem) responsive to elite and popular sentiment.[5]

Thus, one way to pass such measures—while at the same time reducing the regime's reliance on extensive vote fraud or abject coercion to do so—is to construct public support for these changes. Under these circumstances, a public vote offers an attractive mechanism in the authoritarian toolkit.

We demonstrate this argument through in-depth analysis of the 2020 public vote in Russia, which was used to approve extensive changes to the 1993 Constitution. We chose this case for two reasons. First, the process-level information available is extensive, including from contemporaneous polling and media coverage. There is, therefore, ample evidence to draw on in reconstructing the processes at work. Second, Russia's 2020 vote represents a case study of "intrinsic importance," in that it has "an obvious world historic significance."[6] The vote resolved a central political problem within Russia's regime: the considerable uncertainty surrounding what would happen when Vladimir Putin reached the end of his constitutionally permitted time in office. By resetting Putin's term record, the vote enabled regime continuity. Moreover, other authoritarian regimes across the post-Soviet region appear to have observed, learned from, and, to a certain extent, emulated the Russian case from 2020, making the example important for understanding authoritarian diffusion and learning. In the conclusion, we note how the dynamics observed in the Russian case are also visible in other non-democratic settings.

Our analysis contributes three core theoretical and conceptual insights. First, we show that authoritarian rulers can use voluntary referendums to engineer buy-in from different segments of the population. What might easily be dismissed as autocratic political theatre can play a key role in the co-construction of the regime.[7] This insight extends the findings of recent work on authoritarian co-optation and legitimation by suggesting

5 Johannes Gerschewski, "The Three Pillars of Stability: Legitimation, Repression, and Co-Optation in Autocratic Regimes," *Democratization* 20, no. 1 (2013): 13–38, https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2013.738860; Sergei Guriev and Daniel Treisman, "A Theory of Informational Autocracy," *Journal of Public Economics* 186 (2020): 104158, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2020.104158; Dima Kortukov, "'Sovereign Democracy' and the Politics of Ideology in Putin's Russia," *Russian Politics* 5, no. 1 (2020): 81–104, https://doi.org/10.30965/24518921-00501004.

6 John Gerring, *Case Study Research: Principles and Practices*, 2nd edition (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 42, https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316848593.

7 Samuel A. Greene and Graeme B. Robertson, *Putin v. the People: The Perilous Politics of a Divided Russia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2019).

that organizing a public vote is yet another way that rulers try to create support for their policies and for the regime more generally.[8]

Second, authoritarian referendums—whether mandated by the constitution or not—should be conceptualized as more than discrete voting moments. The upstream processes before a vote—of announcing, debating, and campaigning—can be as important as the thumping victories often reported in the official results. Considering referendums as a complex institution makes us sensitive to their uses for authoritarian elites beyond demonstrating regime support or the state's ability to manipulate results. In other words, the positive impacts for authoritarian regimes are not solely found in the obvious parts of the referendum—i.e., the overwhelming victory and the messages that it conveys—but also in the process of getting to that victory.

Third, this ability to use the lead-up to a voluntary referendum to generate support means that autocrats can use these votes to pass controversial policies. A basic stylized fact regarding the difference between democracies and non-democracies is that, in general, there is greater divergence between the preference set of the leadership and the population under authoritarianism.[9] That means that, all else equal, dictators seek to pass more contentious policies than their democratic counterparts. Voluntary referendums are one way that autocrats can use means beyond coercion and material inducements to achieve their desired outcome. Securing nominal and genuine popular support for policies that might otherwise lack widespread endorsement not only provides a veneer of legitimacy for these controversial measures—it can also protect the leader from elite concerns, grievances, or challenges to their rule.

Direct popular votes are often dismissed as "shams" in non-democracies.[10] This term rightly captures the fact that these votes do not function like their democratic namesakes, as they do not provide a real opportunity for the people to have their say. But this does not mean that the process of getting to the official result cannot be revealing. In some cases, results are dictated quickly and by fiat—for example, as seen with the illegal

8 Leonardo R. Arriola, Jed DeVaro, and Anne Meng, "Democratic Subversion: Elite Cooptation and Opposition Fragmentation," *American Political Science Review* 115, no. 4 (2021): 1358–72, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055421000629; Constantine Boussalis, Alexander Dukalskis, and Johannes Gerschewski, "Why It Matters What Autocrats Say: Assessing Competing Theories of Propaganda," *Problems of Post-Communism* 70, no. 3 (2023): 241–52, doi:10.1080/10758216.2021.2012199; Erica Frantz and Andrea Kendall-Taylor, "A Dictator's Toolkit: Understanding how Co-Optation Affects Repression in Autocracies," *Journal of Peace Research* 51, no. 3 (2014): 332–46, https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343313519808; Johannes Gerschewski, "Legitimacy in Autocracies: Oxymoron or Essential Feature?" *Perspectives on Politics* 16, no. 3 (2018): 652–65, https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592717002183; Heike Holbig, "Ideology after the End of Ideology: China and the Quest for Autocratic Legitimation," *Democratization* 20, no. 1 (2013): 61–81, https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2013.738862; Ora John Reuter and Graeme B. Robertson, "Legislatures, Cooptation, and Social Protest in Contemporary Authoritarian Regimes," *The Journal of Politics* 77, no. 1 (2015): 235–48, https://doi.org/10.1086/678390; David Szakonyi, "Corruption and Co-Optation in Autocracy: Evidence from Russia," *American Political Science Review* 119, no. 1 (2025): 402–19, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055424000340.

9 Sergei Guriev and Daniel Treisman, "The Popularity of Authoritarian Leaders," *World Politics* 72, no. 4 (2020): 601–38, https://dx.doi.org/10.1017/s0043887120000167.

10 See, for example, "Ukraine War: Russia Claims Win in Occupied Ukraine 'Sham' Referendums," *BBC News*, September 27, 2022, https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-europe-63052207.

referendums staged by Russia in occupied parts of Ukraine in 2022.[11] In other cases, however, regimes invest significant resources into trying to change voters' minds, even if the authorities take other steps to limit or deny citizens' voices. Across these cases, we can denounce authoritarian referendums as unfree and unfair at the same time as examining their inner workings and usefulness to non-democratic regimes.

Existing Literature

Recent political science research has shown how non-democratic regimes use formal institutions in part to manage relationships between the leader, the ruling elite, and citizens. Once viewed as window-dressing, scholars now agree that these institutions serve important functions in sustaining authoritarian rule, including co-opting members of the ruling class or citizens across different social groups.[12] They also allow dictators to spread the spoils of office,[13] make credible commitments to power-sharing,[14] collect information about public sentiment,[15] and deter defection among members of the elite.[16]

But what about referendums? Recent research has so far largely focused on elections, parties, legislatures, and courts. Although this existing work—as well as the broad

11 Anton Troianovski, "The Quiet Technocrat Who Enacts Putin's Ruthless Agenda," *The New York Times*, August 10, 2025, https://www.nytimes.com/2025/08/10/world/europe/putin-russia-ukraine-war-sergei-kiriyenko.html.

12 Jennifer Gandhi, *Political Institutions under Dictatorship* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008); Jennifer Gandhi and Adam Przeworski, "Cooperation, Cooptation, and Rebellion Under Dictatorships," *Economics & Politics* 18, no. 1 (2006): 1–26, https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-0343.2006.00160.x.

13 Lisa Blaydes, *Elections and Distributive Politics in Mubarak's Egypt* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010); Reuter and Robertson, "Legislatures, Cooptation, and Social Protest."

14 Carles Boix and Milan W. Svolik, "The Foundations of Limited Authoritarian Government: Institutions, Commitment, and Power-Sharing in Dictatorships," *The Journal of Politics* 75, no. 2 (2013): 300–16, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0022381613000029; Beatriz Magaloni, "Credible Power-Sharing and the Longevity of Authoritarian Rule," *Comparative Political Studies* 41, no. 4–5 (2008): 715–41, https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414007313124; Ora John Reuter and Thomas F. Remington, "Dominant Party Regimes and the Commitment Problem: The Case of United Russia," *Comparative Political Studies* 42, no. 4 (2009): 501–26, https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414008327426.

15 Michael K. Miller, "Elections, Information, and Policy Responsiveness in Autocratic Regimes," *Comparative Political Studies* 48, no. 6 (2015): 691–727, https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414014555443; Grigore Pop-Eleches and Graeme B. Robertson, "Information, Elections, and Political Change," *Comparative Politics* 47, no. 4 (2015): 459–78, https://doi.org/10.5129/001041515816103239; Rory Truex, *Making Autocracy Work: Representation and Responsiveness in Modern China* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781316771785.

16 Adrián del Río, "Strategic Uncertainty and Elite Defections in Electoral Autocracies: A Cross-National Analysis," *Comparative Political Studies* 55, no. 13 (2022): 2250–82, https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140221074273; Barbara Geddes, "What Do We Know About Democratization After Twenty Years?" *Annual Review of Political Science* 2 (1999): 115–44, https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.polisci.2.1.115; Steven Levitsky and Lucan Way, "Beyond Patronage: Violent Struggle, Ruling Party Cohesion, and Authoritarian Durability," *Perspectives on Politics* 10, no. 4 (2012): 869–89, https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592712002861; Milan W. Svolik, "Power Sharing and Leadership Dynamics in Authoritarian Regimes," *American Journal of Political Science* 53, no. 2 (2009): 477–94, https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-5907.2009.00382.x.

literature on referendums in democracies—provides a useful starting point when thinking about what roles or functions public votes might play in non-democracies, there are important reasons to think that existing knowledge cannot simply be transposed onto this understudied institution.[17] Unlike elections, referendums are not used to place individuals into positions of public office; instead, they are used to put particular policy and constitutional questions to the people. This means that analyzing referendums—especially when they are organized voluntarily by political leaders—can potentially reveal more direct information about topics of interest and concern to the political leadership. Additionally, whereas elections are usually subject to relatively rigid, constitutionally fixed timetables, not just the fact but also the timing of a referendum is often within the ruler's discretion. This makes these events especially intriguing, as they can provide insights into the leadership's strategic calculus.

Scholars have only recently begun to systematically analyze the role of referendums in authoritarian regimes. In an agenda-setting paper, Qvortrup, O'Leary, and Wintrobe ask why autocrats bother holding referendums that they are certain they will win.[18] They operationalize this outcome by focusing on the narrow set of cases in which the issue (or package of issues) put to a vote passes with at least 99 percent support. Through cross-national regression analysis, they find that such referendums are more likely in regimes that have sultanistic forms of autocracy and high levels of ethnic heterogeneity, which they see as consistent with the argument that these votes are motivated by a desire "to intimidate and control the population."[19]

Penadés and Velasco advance this research agenda by analyzing all authoritarian referendums held between 1946 and 2008.[20] They find that referendums are more likely to be held in the early years of a ruler's tenure; in military dictatorships, compared with civilian regimes and monarchies; and in autocracies where a multi-party parliament exists. They conclude that these results offer support for their claim that such events are "part of a repressive strategy with the objective of hindering internal regime rivals and

17 For overviews of the literature on democratic referendums, see Ian Budge, "Direct Democracy," in Sarah Binder, R. A. W. Rhodes, and Bert A. Rockman, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of Political Institutions* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008); Celine Colombo and Hanspeter Kriesi, "Referendums and Direct Democracy," in Robert Rohrschneider and Jacques Thomassen, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of Political Representation in Liberal Democracies* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2020), https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780198825081.001.0001; Arthur Lupia and John G. Matsusaka, "Direct Democracy: New Approaches to Old Questions," *Annual Review of Political Science* 7 (2004): 463–82, https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.polisci.7.012003.104730; John Matsusaka, "Direct Democracy and Public Policy," in Roger D. Congleton, Bernard Grofman, and Stefan Voigt, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of Public Choice* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019), https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780190469733.001.0001; Laurence Morel, "Referendum," in Michel Rosenfeld and András Sajó, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of Comparative Constitutional Law* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199578610.001.0001; Matt Qvortrup, "Direct Democracy and Referendums," in Erik Herron, Robert Pekkanen, and Matthew Shugart, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of Electoral Systems* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780190258658.001.0001.

18 Qvortrup, O'Leary, and Wintrobe, "Explaining the Paradox of Plebiscites."

19 Qvortrup, O'Leary, and Wintrobe, "Explaining the Paradox of Plebiscites," 216.

20 Penadés and Velasco, "Plebiscites."

discouraging the coordination of the external opposition."[21] In follow-up investigations, they find that the frequent use of referendums occurs in autocracies that are both personalist and pluralist,[22] and that authoritarian regimes experience lower levels of popular mobilization and fewer elite coups in the years following a referendum, which they interpret as further evidence that holding a public vote serves to suppress real and potential opponents to the regime.[23]

Examining a different set of cases, Fruhstorfer analyzes constitutional referendums in post-Soviet states.[24] Fruhstorfer argues that rulers use these votes to advance their political agendas in the face of elite disunity, noting that referendums are less common in states with hegemonic ruling parties. In short, when autocrats cannot rely on the elite—especially parliamentarians—to cooperate, they take the issue to the people.

These works provide important initial steps in understanding authoritarian referendums. But much more remains to be done. Most obviously, this existing work masks the complexity of the outcome to be explained in three main ways. First, these studies largely gloss over the distinction between referendums that are mandated by the constitution and those that are not. And yet, there is important variation in this regard. Of the 413 direct popular votes carried out in non-democracies and included in the V-Dem dataset for the 1945–2020 time period, 249 (60 percent) were voluntary referendums and 159 (38 percent) were constitutionally required referendums.[25] There is reason to believe that the dynamics of voluntary versus constitutionally required referendums could vary significantly. At a basic level, they have different generative processes, given that some arise from constitutional requirements while others derive from the ruler's deliberate choice. Consequently, those votes mandated by the basic law might, all else equal, be regarded as formalities, whereas voluntary referendums are initiated as opportunities for broader goals.

Second, existing work pays little attention to the substance of measures put to the people. This makes sense given the focus in these works on the use of referendums to manage the real and potential opposition: if the main goal of referendums in non-democracies is to repress through demonstrations of the state's capacity to achieve overwhelming victories, then the content of ballots is of secondary importance. But the substance of referendums can reveal important information, including about those topics of most concern to a particular regime at that moment in time, as well as how those points put to the people might be crafted to engineer support.

21 Penadés and Velasco, "Plebiscites," 74.

22 Penadés and Velasco-Monje, "Authoritarian Personalism."

23 Penadés and Velasco, "The Effect of Referendums on Autocratic Survival."

24 Anna Fruhstorfer, "Referendums and Autocratization: Explaining Constitutional Referendums in the Post-Soviet Space," in Richard Albert and Richard Stacey, eds., *The Limits and Legitimacy of Referendums* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2022), https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198867647.001.0001.

25 V-Dem uses the term "plebiscites" for what we call "voluntary referendums." We do not use the term "plebiscite" in this article, as there is considerable variation in the term's usage in academic and general writing, with some using it to distinguish votes initiated in a bottom-up fashion (e.g., citizen initiatives) from those instigated by the government, legislature, or other sections of the ruling elite. Five cases of "popular initiatives"—citizen-initiated votes—are recorded by V-Dem in non-democracies, 1945–2020, making up 1 percent of the overall set. The respective percentages do not add up to 100 percent due to rounding.

Third, recent studies focus on the discrete act of holding a referendum, defined by the moment that citizens go to the polls or the announcement of the regime's overwhelming victory. Yet, in some cases, this endpoint is the product of months of information gathering and organizational efforts by the regime that shape not just the ultimate outcome but, often, the government's decision to hold a referendum in the first place. By centering attention on the fact of the vote, these analyses skip over how the regime ends up with the final numbers that it reports.

Beyond these points about the outcome to be explained, the empirical strategies adopted thus far leave many aspects unexplored. Existing studies assess whether a referendum happened (or not) in a given country-year. The reliance on large-N regression and country-year observations is suitable for initial work on information-poor environments.[26] But this approach privileges structural explanations. While this type of research design can help make sense of cross-national variation, it is less able to explain variation over time in the same country. Uncovering the strategic decision-making behind the use of referendums within one country requires different empirical strategies, including focusing on micro-level behavior, the information and actions available to actors, and the roles of timing and sequencing in shaping their decisions. This strategy may have previously been seen as unfeasible due to data limitations, but recent work shows the sometimes-surprising availability of information on authoritarian regimes, allowing us to peer inside what have previously been regarded as "black boxes."[27]

We propose a new theory of voluntary referendums in non-democracies to push forward this emerging research agenda. In the next section, we first consider why rulers might decide to put their proposals to a public vote when they are not constitutionally required to do so. We then identify how the process of organizing a referendum can generate buy-in from key constituencies. This approach allows us to uncover an otherwise overlooked dynamic: that rulers can voluntarily organize public votes in order to build support for controversial initiatives.

A Theory of Voluntary Authoritarian Referendums

Why Hold Voluntary Referendums? Across political contexts, referendums are often used to enact significant political changes.[28] In autocracies, rulers seeking to

26 Ariel I. Ahram and J. Paul Goode, "Researching Authoritarianism in the Discipline of Democracy," *Social Science Quarterly* 97, no. 4 (2016): 834–49, https://doi.org/10.1111/ssqu.12340; J. Paul Goode, "Redefining Russia: Hybrid Regimes, Fieldwork, and Russian Politics," *Perspectives on Politics* 8, no. 4 (2010): 1055–75, https://doi.org/10.1017/S153759271000318X.

27 Ruth D. Carlitz and Rachel McLellan, "Open Data from Authoritarian Regimes: New Opportunities, New Challenges," *Perspectives on Politics* 19, no. 1 (2021): 160–70, https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592720001346.

28 Zachary Elkins and Alexander Hudson, "The Constitutional Referendum in Historical Perspective," in David Landau and Hanna Lerner, eds., *Comparative Constitution Making* (Cheltenham, UK: Edward Elgar, 2019); Nanuli Silagadze and Sergiu Gherghina, "Referendum Policies across Political Systems," *The Political Quarterly* 91, no. 1 (2020): 181–91, https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-923X.12790.

pursue such changes have to at least consider the potential reaction from two domestic audiences.[29] They must maintain the confidence of the ruling elites—those who, if antagonized, could launch a campaign against the ruler, block their policies, or subtly undermine the ruler's authority through public statements and private rumors.[30] At the same time, rulers also require at least tacit support from their citizens.[31] Although often beset by the challenges of collective action and the forces of state repression, the power of the citizens rests in the sheer force of their numbers and their ability to take to the streets to express their displeasure.[32] These constituencies may genuinely support whatever policies the ruler is proposing, or, at least, might not actively oppose them.[33] But opposition may be expected from different segments of society if the proposals contradict elite or popular interests, ideological commitments, or beliefs about how the country should be governed.[34] We use the term "controversial" to describe policies that the ruler seeks to pass under these circumstances.

Rulers seeking to enact a potentially controversial political change face a dilemma. Backing down in the face of resistance is not always feasible, especially when the policy proposal is designed to solve a pressing problem. But enacting these changes by fiat, such as via an executive decree, can be seen as an erosion of the power-sharing and co-optive agreements that underpin the regime.[35] Moreover, such measures would likely need to be accompanied by coercive measures—either in terms of elite purges or

29 Milan W. Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012).

30 Boix and Svolik, "The Foundations of Limited Authoritarian Government;" Georgy Egorov and Konstantin Sonin, "Dictators and Their Viziers: Endogenizing the Loyalty–Competence Trade-off," *Journal of the European Economic Association* 9, no. 5 (2011): 903–30, https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1542-4774.2011.01033.x; Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright, and Erica Frantz, *How Dictatorships Work* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2018); Nam Kyu Kim and Jun Koga Sudduth, "Political Institutions and Coups in Dictatorships," *Comparative Political Studies* 54, no. 9 (2021): 1597–628, https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414021997161; Anne Meng, *Constraining Dictatorship: From Personalized Rule to Institutionalized Regimes* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020); Anne Meng, Jack Paine, and Robert Powell, "Authoritarian Power Sharing: Concepts, Mechanisms, and Strategies," *Annual Review of Political Science* 26 (2023): 153–73, https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-052121-020406.

31 Johannes Gerschewski, *The Two Logics of Autocratic Rule* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023); Mai Hassan, Daniel Mattingly, and Elizabeth R. Nugent, "Political Control," *Annual Review of Political Science* 25 (2022): 155–74, https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-051120-013321; Daniel Mattingly, *The Art of Political Control* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019); Adam Przeworski, "Formal Models of Authoritarian Regimes: A Critique," *Perspectives on Politics* 21, no. 3 (2023): 979–88, https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592722002067.

32 Daron Acemoglu and James Robinson, *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006); Carles Boix, *Democracy and Redistribution* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003); Debra Javeline, *Protest and the Politics of Blame: The Russian Response to Unpaid Wages* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2003); Graeme B. Robertson, *The Politics of Protest in Hybrid Regimes* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010).

33 Greene and Robertson, *Putin v. the People*; Aleksandar Matovski, *Popular Dictatorships: Crises, Mass Opinion, and the Rise of Electoral Authoritarianism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2021), https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009047500.

34 Ludger Helms, "Twenty-First Century Autocrats and Their Followers: A Comparative Inquiry," *Politics and Governance* 13 (2025), 1–16, https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.9065.

35 Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*; Gandhi, *Political Institutions under Dictatorship*.

a broader crackdown against political dissent in society—which would risk provoking further discontent on all sides. An alternative for the ruler is to generate support for their controversial political change. We suggest that referendums provide a mechanism to do this—and this, therefore, explains why rulers would voluntarily decide to organize a public vote. Specifically, the iterative process of constructing the vote can shape the content and procedures involved in the vote, and, in doing so, have an effect on the willingness of the elite and the population to support the proposed measures.

How Can Organizing Referendums Generate Support? Unlike mandatory referendums, in which voting content and procedures are necessarily more prescribed, organizing a voluntary referendum involves significant decisions and negotiations with elites before the vote happens—to settle on the details, finalize the proposals, and organize the conduct of the vote. It also provides opportunities to solicit input from elite groups and citizens, and to engage in campaigns to emphasize the more palatable aspects (if any) of the proposals.

In the initial stages, rulers can open up space for the elite to offer input on the best ways to proceed. Even if the feedback from these elite figures and groups is not binding on the ruler, it allows members of the elite to signal if they oppose the measures or if they think them unwise. Unlike elections, referendums can, in principle, contain questions on multiple issues, including things that have little to do with each other. The ruler can use this flexibility to buy off political and social elites by putting their pet projects and favored political items in the package of changes to be voted on.

This ability to combine different measures can also help build support within the population. By including truly popular policies, rulers can deflect citizens' attention from the core, controversial policy, or policies, at hand. This tactic is especially effective if the entire package of questions is put to a single "yes/no" vote, making it impossible for citizens to vote against more controversial elements without rejecting the whole package. In the longer run, this strategy can also help neutralize the threat of rejection or allegations of fraud after the results are announced. Including popular points makes it plausible that an overwhelming majority of citizens has, in fact, turned out and endorsed the package, even if they were opposed to (or ambivalent about) some measures within it. And, by holding a public vote, the ruler can point to the official result as a formal endorsement of the package as a whole from the people.

Being able to speak directly to voters to convince them of the advantages of the proposals is a key benefit of the referendum process for rulers. Rulers can use the pre-referendum period to gauge the mass popularity of particular measures. This information can, in turn, be used to decide where to focus more intense campaigning and how to frame the message for different demographic groups. Government officials and their proxies can hold public meetings with key constituencies; make media appearances; solicit endorsements from public intellectuals, cultural authorities, and national celebrities; and organize countrywide advertising campaigns. Such efforts can change the minds of undecided or unsure voters and convince them to vote in favor based on the merits of the policy or as a broader endorsement of the ruler and the regime.

In short, voluntary referendums do not simply codify existing support. Nor are vote rigging, coercion, and material inducements the only important factors in explaining how impressive victories are achieved. We also have to take account of how the process of organizing a referendum creates votes in favor of the government's proposals. The organizational decisions that are made about seemingly granular details can serve to build up support—and ultimately, legitimacy—for the end result. This "manufactured consent" makes it seem plausible that the ruler's proposal has been endorsed by a sizeable majority of citizens.

Empirical Strategy

Our theory suggests that, if an autocrat has successfully organized a voluntary referendum to engineer buy-in for a controversial policy, we would expect to see that:

1. The core policy put to voters addresses a significant political issue, but the change is opposed by at least a sizable minority of citizens.
2. The authorities meaningfully invest in efforts to construct support for the policy, or package of policies, with the elite and the people.
3. There is an observable increase in popular support for the measures put to a vote during this process.

We demonstrate the plausibility of our account through analysis of Russia's 2020 public vote on constitutional amendments. While a single case study does not constitute a robust test of our theory, it allows us to illustrate the generative processes and strategic decisions involved. Our empirical analysis draws on an extensive range of qualitative sources, including articles from Russian media outlets, international news reports, public comments and speeches by Russian officials, and state documents. This is complemented by survey data to trace shifts in public opinion over time concerning the measures being put to a vote, as well as activities related to the vote. Naturally, questions arise about the accuracy of polling data in an authoritarian context. Indeed, there is evidence of discrepancies between independent and state-owned pollsters in Russia, which could simply reflect differences in wording or, more worryingly, political pressure on organizations to report regime-friendly results rather than true attitudes. It could also reflect pre-emptive censorship.[36] And yet, even if exact reported levels cannot be treated as robust, changes over time regarding the same question by the same pollster can be treated more confidently.

Russia's 2020 Public Vote on Constitutional Changes

On January 15, 2020, Vladimir Putin announced plans to revise the 1993 Russian Constitution. In his annual "state of the nation" address to the Federal Assembly—Russia's bicameral national legislature, consisting of the State Duma and the Federation Council—Putin

36 Margarita Zavadskaya, "On the harmfulness of Russian polls," *Riddle*, May 4, 2022, https://ridl.io/on-the-harmfulness-of-russian-polls/.

proposed a wide range of constitutional amendments, from formal guarantees of social support, to a rebalancing of political power, to an emphasis on sovereignty.[37]

The address was surprising for several reasons. First, Putin had previously stated opposition to significant changes to the 1993 Constitution.[38] Second, the proposed changes provided little clarity regarding what Putin would do at the end of his fourth presidential term in 2024, when he would, according to the wording of the Constitution then in force, be required to step down. This term limit constraint was referred to as his "2024 problem," and was a topic of intense speculation at the time. Indeed, 47 percent of Russians polled in January 2020 by an independent organization thought that the constitutional changes were being made so that Putin could increase his powers and remain in power beyond 2024.[39] But Putin's initial January 2020 address did not articulate how his proposed changes might enable him to remain in office. Third, the address concluded with an announcement that the whole package of proposals would need to be approved by a "vote of the country's citizens" in order to enter into force.[40] But such a vote was not required: according to constitutional rules, the proposed amendments would need to be adopted by at least two thirds of State Duma deputies, by at least three quarters of Federation Council members, and by at least two thirds of Russia's regional assemblies—but the amendments did not require public approval.[41] In spite of this, the president argued that, in this instance, it was "necessary to hold a [popular] vote."[42]

Why did Putin insist on putting his constitutional change proposals to the people? In line with the theory developed above, we argue that the answer lies in the ability of referendums to proclaim and build support for controversial initiatives. Each sub-section below offers evidence for the three empirical expectations noted above.

To help follow the analysis, we first lay out the broad sequence of events. After Putin's January 2020 speech, the president introduced a bill containing his proposals into the State Duma; this bill was swiftly adopted in its first reading on January 23.[43] But even

37 Elizabeth Teague, "Russia's Constitutional Reforms of 2020," *Russian Politics* 5, no. 3 (2020): 301–28, https://doi.org/10.30965/24518921-00503003.

38 Current Time, "Watch Putin Talk About Not Changing the Constitution. Now He Says It's OK," *Radio Free Europe / Radio Liberty*, March 12, 2020, https://www.rferl.org/a/years-of-denial-putin-said-repeatedly-he-would-not-change-constitution-/30484258.html; CBS, "Putin says he'll observe term limits preventing 2024 presidential run," May 25, 2018, https://www.cbsnews.com/news/russian-president-vladimir-putin-observe-term-limits-preventing-2024-presidential-run-2018-05-25/.

39 Levada Center, "Rol' Konstitutsii [The Role of the Constitution]," January 31, 2020, https://www.levada.ru/2020/01/31/konstitutsiya/.

40 Vladimir Putin, "Presidential Address to the Federal Assembly," January 15, 2020, http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/62582.

41 See Article 108, section 2, and Article 136 of Russia's 1993 Constitution.

42 Putin, "Presidential Address," 2020.

43 In the Russian law-making process, normal draft legislation must clear three readings in the State Duma in order to progress to the upper chamber, the Federation Council, after which it is sent to the president for approval and promulgation as law. Regarding Duma readings, the overall concept of a bill is evaluated in its first reading. If a bill is approved at this first stage, then amendments are proposed before the bill is voted on in its amended form in second reading. The third reading is used to approve the final version of a bill, including tweaks of a purely technical-legal nature; no substantive amendments can be made at this stage.

before the bill's introduction, the president initiated a period of public consultations on his proposals, which resulted in changes made to the bill that were approved during its second legislative reading on March 10.[44] From that point, the bill passed swiftly over the remaining formal institutional hurdles. It was adopted in its third Duma reading on March 11, after which it was approved by the Federation Council on the same day. The Council confirmed approval by all federal subjects (regions) on March 14, after which Putin signed the bill on the same day, and the Russian Constitutional Court ruled the changes constitutional on March 16.

But the bill was drafted such that the constitutional changes would only come into effect if the entire package was approved by voters.[45] The vote was initially planned to take place on April 22, 2020, but was delayed due to the Covid-19 pandemic.[46] The authorities eventually rescheduled it to run across multiple days, from June 25 to July 1, ostensibly to allow for social distancing. In the run-up to the vote, Russia's Central Election Commission (CEC) ran an information campaign, but prevented official campaigning for or against the constitutional amendment package. In the end, the official result stated that nearly 80 percent of voters approved of the package of changes. However, the independent Russian election and vote monitoring organization, Golos, heavily criticized the vote, noting that it "will go down in history as an attack on the sovereignty of the people."[47]

Controversial Policy Change The core policy change that was put to Russian voters related to presidential term limits, a proposal that was both manifestly self-interested for Vladimir Putin and lacked strong popular support at the outset.

By early 2020, Putin faced a problem. The original version of the 1993 Constitution stated that "one and the same person cannot hold the position of President of the Russian Federation for more than two terms consecutively."[48] The last word, "consecutively" (*podryad*), proved consequential, as this had allowed Putin to return to the presidency earlier, in 2012, for a third term after stepping into the role of prime minister during Dmitry Medvedev's 2008–2012 term as president. But in his January 2020 speech, Putin stated that he supported removing the word "consecutively" from Article 81 to close a constitutional loophole he himself had exploited. Doing so would mean that he would

44 For a detailed discussion of these changes, see Teague, "Russia's Constitutional Reforms."

45 The Russian term for the vote was *obshcherossiyskoe golosovanie* (literally, an "all-Russian vote")—a form of vote that was, up to that point, undefined in Russian law. Nevertheless, as a state-administered direct popular vote open to the whole electorate but not used to elect individuals to office, this vote was a referendum. See Ben Noble and Nikolay Petrov, "From Constitution to Law: Implementing the 2020 Russian Constitutional Changes," *Russian Politics* 6, no. 1 (2021): 130–52, https://doi.org/10.30965/24518921-00601008.

46 BBC News, "Coronavirus delays Russian vote on Putin staying in power," March 25, 2020, https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-52038814.

47 BBC News, "Putin strongly backed in controversial Russian reform vote," July 2, 2020, https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-europe-53255964.

48 See Article 81, section 3 of Russia's 1993 Constitution (unamended).

reach the limit on his time in office in 2024; it would no longer be possible to step away from the presidency in 2024 and return at a future point, as he had done previously.

Polling conducted by the independent Levada Center in July 2019 suggested that nearly 40 percent of Russians did not want Putin to remain president at the end of his then-current term; this was up significantly from around 20 percent in August 2017.[49] Furthermore, although Putin's approval rating at the end of 2019 and beginning of 2020 was a comparatively healthy 68 percent, this was a marked fall from figures in the high 80s after Russia's illegal annexation of Crimea from Ukraine in 2014.[50] One key moment in this drop in popularity came following deeply unpopular pension reforms pushed through in 2018, shortly after Putin's re-election to the presidency. And, in 2019, Russia saw street protests coordinated by the leading opposition figure, Alexei Navalny, and on a scale not seen since the 2011–2012 protests after fraudulent national legislative elections.[51] Many began to ask how Putin would maintain, re-boost, or legitimate his long rule.

The solution eventually included in the package of constitutional changes was simple but effective: Putin's existing record of four presidential terms was set to zero. Specifically, the term records of those individuals who currently held, or had held, presidential office (i.e., Vladimir Putin and Dmitry Medvedev) would be "zeroed." This removed the requirement for Putin to step down in 2024. He would now be able to remain president until 2036—if he chose to participate in the 2024 and 2030 elections—by which point he would have served the maximum total of two terms. But this term record reset was controversial: according to end-of-March 2020 polling, the modal response to a question about whether respondents approved of the "zeroing" amendment was "definitely not" (30 percent of respondents).[52]

Throughout the process, the initiatives eventually put to a vote were packaged in a way that obscured this contentious policy change. Putin made no reference to this presidential term limit reform in his January 2020 address. It was also not included in the set of amendments formally considered by the lead Duma committee before the bill's second reading. Rather, a State Duma deputy, Valentina Tereshkova—the first woman in space and a national hero—proposed the change as a last-minute amendment on the Duma floor during second reading on March 10, two months after Putin's initial speech.[53]

Although presented as a spontaneous suggestion from a parliamentarian, informed, Tereshkova claimed, by pleas from the Russian people, this was, in fact, a carefully choreographed piece of political theatre.[54] Soon after Tereshkova's proposal, Vladimir

49 Levada Center, "Prezident: Doverie i Golosovanie [President: Trust and Voting]," July 30, 2019, https://www.levada.ru/2019/07/30/prezident-doverie-i-golosovanie/.

50 Levada Center, "Indikatory: Odobrenie Deyatel'nosti Vladimira Putina [Indicators: Approval of Vladimir Putin's Activities]," (no date), https://www.levada.ru/indikatory/.

51 BBC News, "Moscow protests: Opposition rally 'largest since 2011'," August 10, 2019, https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-europe-49305129.

52 Levada Center, "Obnulenie Prezidentskikh Srokov [Zeroing of Presidential Terms]," March 27, 2020, https://www.levada.ru/2020/03/27/obnulenie-prezidentskih-srokov/.

53 Tereshkova also floated the idea of removing term limits entirely.

54 Andrei Pertsev, "Gosduma neozhidanno dlya sebya obespechila Putina novymi prezidentskimi srokami [The State Duma unexpectedly provided Putin with new presidential terms]," *Meduza*, March 10,

Putin himself entered the State Duma's plenary hall and gave his assent to the change. It appears, therefore, that the Kremlin was concerned with keeping Putin one step removed from this self-interested, controversial constitutional change for as long as possible—and to frame it as an initiative demanded by the people.

Investments in Constructing Support for the Package Throughout the pre-referendum period, the regime took specific steps to generate support from the elite and society by soliciting input from a wide range of political and social actors. They also "sugar-coated" the term limit change with much more popular proposals and then launched a public campaign to sell the package of measures to voters.

Elite Input and Societal Input The Kremlin was keen to create opportunities for both elites and voters to contribute to the organizational process. Indeed, Putin framed the whole constitutional change process as a broad "public discussion" in his January 2020 address. He noted that "the proposals made [by me] today, by no means limit the discussion around possible amendments to the Constitution. I am sure that public associations, parties, regions, the legal community, and Russian citizens will express their ideas."[55]

Preliminary public consultations centered on a working group that Putin formed on the same day as his speech proposing constitutional changes. The working group was charged with three tasks: to provide input on Putin's own proposals; to collect and evaluate proposals for constitutional changes in line with, and beyond, those made by Putin; and to work out the precise mechanism for the vote.[56] The group consisted of seventy-five members, including academics, federal and regional legislators, heads of business interest groups, trade union leaders, sportspeople, cultural figures, representatives of national and ethnic groups, and leaders of societal organizations.[57] The group was headed by two parliamentarians, Andrei Klishas and Pavel Krasheninnikov, and a constitutional law expert, Taliya Khabrieva.

2020, https://meduza.io/feature/2020/03/10/gosduma-neozhidanno-dlya-sebya-obespechila-putina-novymi-prezidentskimi-srokami.

55 Putin, "Presidential Address," 2020.

56 Aleksandr Baklanov, "Rabochaya gruppa po reforme Konstitutsii predlozhila izmenit' 14 ee statey. Popravki razrabotali za odin den' [The working group on reform of the Constitution proposed to change 14 articles. The amendments were developed in one day]," *Meduza*, January 20, 2020, https://meduza.io/feature/2020/01/20/rabochaya-gruppa-po-reforme-konstitutsii-predlozhila-izmenit-14-ee-statey; TASS, "Rabochaya gruppa po popravkam v Konstitutsiyu vyrabotaet mekhanizm obshcherossiyskogo golosovaniya [The working group on amendments to the Constitution will work out the mechanism of the nationwide vote]," January 19, 2020, https://tass.ru/politika/7554041; Mikhail Yushkov, "Rabochaya gruppa po popravkam v Konstitutsiyu predlozhit variant izmeneniy [The working group on amendments to the Constitution will propose a variant of changes]," *RBK*, January 19, 2020, https://www.rbc.ru/politics/19/01/2020/5e2448b59a7947110830be6f.

57 Kremlin, "Obrazovana rabochaya gruppa po podgotovke predlozheniy o vnesenii popravok v Konstitutsiyu [A working group on preparing proposals for introducing amendments to the Constitution has been formed]," January 15, 2020, http://www.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/62589.

The working group ran in parallel to, but was also integrated with, the legislative process. The group provided feedback on the president's proposals before Putin's bill was introduced into the State Duma on January 20—five days after his initial address. The group then collected and reviewed proposals, with a view to preparing a set of amendments before the bill's second reading. This second stage was originally scheduled for February 11, but the date was pushed back to March 10, ostensibly due to the sheer number of proposed amendments to the bill.

Around 1,000 proposals were eventually submitted to the working group.[58] And over 350 amendments were formally considered by the State Duma Committee on State Construction and Legislation before second reading. Many of these amendments were formally sponsored by the parliamentarian chairs of the working group, Krasheninnikov and Klishas. But other actors with the authority to introduce and amend legislation also submitted proposals, including the president himself, Federation Council members, and State Duma deputies. The Committee, chaired by Krasheninnikov, made recommendations regarding which proposed amendments the Duma should vote to approve and which to reject.

This consultation process allowed the pet projects of specific groups to be included, giving the Kremlin opportunities to co-opt group support for the broader package of changes. For example, the Russian Orthodox Church successfully lobbied for the inclusion of a reference to God in the constitution, even though Article 14 states that Russia is "a secular state."[59] The process also allowed the authorities to project an image of inclusive deliberation. This was reflected, for instance, in frequent reporting on the large number of proposals made over time.[60]

Package of Proposals and Ballot Structure The set of constitutional changes eventually put to the people was constructed in a way that downplayed the core policy change. Specifically, the measure to reset Putin's presidential term record was surrounded by much more popular proposals. In addition, the whole package of measures was put up for a "yes/no" vote.

The "zeroing" amendment was merely one of 206 constitutional changes included in the package put up for approval or rejection on the ballot.[61] And these other changes were far more popular. For example, according to the state-owned polling agency VTsIOM,

58 Interfax, "Putin vnes v Gosdumu novye popravki k Konstitutsii [Putin has submitted new amendments to the Constitution to the State Duma]," March 2, 2020, https://www.interfax.ru/russia/697419; State Duma, "Itogi sessii Gosudarstvennoy Dumy: kak vnosilis' popravki v Konstitutsiyu [Results of the State Duma session: how amendments were made to the Constitution]," July 24, 2020, https://duma.gov.ru/news/49164/.

59 Current Time, "God Could Soon Have a Place in Russia's Constitution," June 24, 2020, https://en.currenttime.tv/a/god-could-soon-have-a-place-in-russia-s-constitution/30688781.html.

60 Galina Mislivskaya, "Srok podachi predlozheniy po izmeneniyu Konstitutsiyu [sic] prodlili do 14 fevralya [The deadline for submitting proposals for amending the Constitution has been extended to 14 February]," *Rossiyskaya Gazeta,* February 4, 2020, https://rg.ru/2020/02/04/srok-podachi-predlozhenij-po-izmeneniiu-konstituciiu-prodlili-do-14-fevralia.html.

61 For a detailed discussion of these changes, see Teague, "Russia's Constitutional Reforms."

around 90 percent of Russians approved of the amendment to index pensions annually.[62] Other popular changes included constitutionally codifying marriage as a union between a man and a woman; formalizing Russian as the language of the "state-forming people;" enacting protections for the state's historical narratives; and instituting a guarantee that the minimum wage would never fall below the subsistence minimum. In effect, the "zeroing" amendment was "sugar-coated" in, and shrouded by, measures that had widespread support. This was crucial, as the vote would be on all amendments together; Russians would not have the opportunity to vote separately on different constitutional changes.

In addition, the "zeroing" amendment was downplayed in the pre-vote information campaign.[63] In an official information booklet produced by Russia's Central Election Commission, amendments were grouped into twelve sections, with short texts presented about the nature and supposed importance of specific proposals.[64] In section 7 on amendments relating to "Stability and Development," there was no mention of the "zeroing" amendment in the introductory text; the text of section 3.1 of Article 81 of the Constitution, which related to "zeroing," was simply provided at the bottom of the page. By contrast, the authorities invested heavily in highlighting the more popular proposals.

The set of constitutional changes posed a clear challenge to the political opposition. Crucially, it was difficult for the opposition to campaign against changes in the overall package that were framed by the authorities as patriotic reforms that would make Russia stronger, and many of which were genuinely popular.[65] The co-opted, "systemic" opposition was divided. Along with all other parties with seats in the State Duma, the Communist Party (KPRF) voted in support of Putin's bill in its first reading, but KPRF legislators abstained in the bill's second and third readings.[66] The Communist Party leadership then actively called for its supporters to vote "no" in the popular vote.[67] This caused little trouble in the State Duma, and in society more broadly, given the dominance of the Kremlin's "party of power," United Russia, but Vladimir Putin still called

62 VTsIOM (2020), https://bd.wciom.ru/survey/sputnik/questions/496fa497-1915-496f-aa55-b4a8a2ab7f7b/total/259d44eb-d1e2-4a57-9905-1bda2acb0e13.

63 Ilya Shepelin, "The Kremlin Is Working Overtime to Promote the New Constitution—Just Not the 'Putin Forever' Part," *The Moscow Times*, June 16, 2020, https://www.themoscowtimes.com/2020/06/16/the-kremlin-is-working-overtime-to-promote-the-new-constitution-just-not-the-putin-forever-part-a70590.

64 CEC, "Popravki k Konstitutsii: Pochemu Eto Vazhno [Amendments to the Constitution: Why it is Important]," (2020), https://rfsv.ru/uploads/buklet%20cik.pdf.

65 These dynamics are in line with the expectations of recent scholarship on referendums. But existing work has not paid attention to specific features of referendums, such as the structure of the ballot and the measures being voted on. More importantly, existing work has explicitly rejected the idea that authoritarian referendums can form part of the "inclusive repertoire of the dictator's bag of tricks" (Penadés and Velasco, "Plebiscites," 74), including the idea that pre-vote steps can be used to build genuine support.

66 For vote results, see the bill's webpage: https://sozd.duma.gov.ru/bill/885214-7.

67 Olga Tikhomirova, "KPRF nachala kampaniyu protiv popravok v Konstitutsiyu [KPRF has begun a campaign against the amendments to the Constitution]," *Deutsche Welle*, June 5, 2020, https://www.dw.com/ru/кпрф-начала-кампанию-против-поправок-в-конституцию/a-53695654. The KPRF leadership argued that the changes had been adopted quickly, without proper discussion, and did not properly reform the 1993 Constitution.

the KPRF's approach "strange."[68] The genuine, "non-systemic" political opposition in Russia was also divided, though in their case they were split between backing a boycott of the vote and rallying around the "no" vote.[69]

Public Campaign The Russian authorities and pro-regime actors invested heavily in selling the measures to voters in the run-up to the vote through videos circulated on social media and broadcast on television, as well as street banners and posters put up across the country. This was in spite of the CEC claiming that neither campaigning for nor against the amendments was possible; rather, informing citizens about the proposed changes was the only activity allowed.[70] And yet, there is evidence from other non-democratic contexts that even "non-partisan information and get-out-the-vote campaigns can further tilt the uneven playing field in competitive authoritarian elections."[71]

Much of the informational content produced by the state was predictably skewed to make the case for the proposed changes. For instance, the official booklet on the proposed changes put together by the CEC stated: "Values, traditions, sovereignty and state unity are the foundation on which our country stands. Amendments to the Constitution strengthen this foundation."[72] The Russian authorities, it would seem, sought to increase support for the changes, rather than allowing for honest discussion and evaluation.

Russian citizens' awareness of these campaign materials can be tracked through the nationally representative "Sputnik" polls, conducted by VTsIOM.[73] Other polling was carried out by different organizations in the run-up to the vote, including by Alexei Navalny's Anti-Corruption Foundation (FBK), by the Russian Political Culture Research Center (TsIPKR), and by the Levada Center. However, the "Sputnik" polls

68 Vedomosti, "Putin nazval strannoy pozitsiyu KPRF po povodu popravok v Konstitutsiyu [Putin called the KPRF's position on constitutional amendments strange]," June 14, 2020, https://www.vedomosti.ru/politics/news/2020/06/14/832532-putin-kprf.

69 According to one opposition activist, the split between voting "no" and boycotting came down to "a moral choice between speaking out by voting against and making a stand by ignoring all political initiatives endorsed by Putin" (Matthew Luxmoore, "Inside the 'Nyet' Campaign: Russia's Divided Opposition and the Doomed Battle to Scupper Putin's Vote," *Radio Free Europe / Radio Liberty*, July 1, 2020, https://www.rferl.org/a/inside-the-nyet-campaign-russia-s-divided-opposition-and-the-doomed-battle-to-scupper-putin-s-vote/30701128.html).

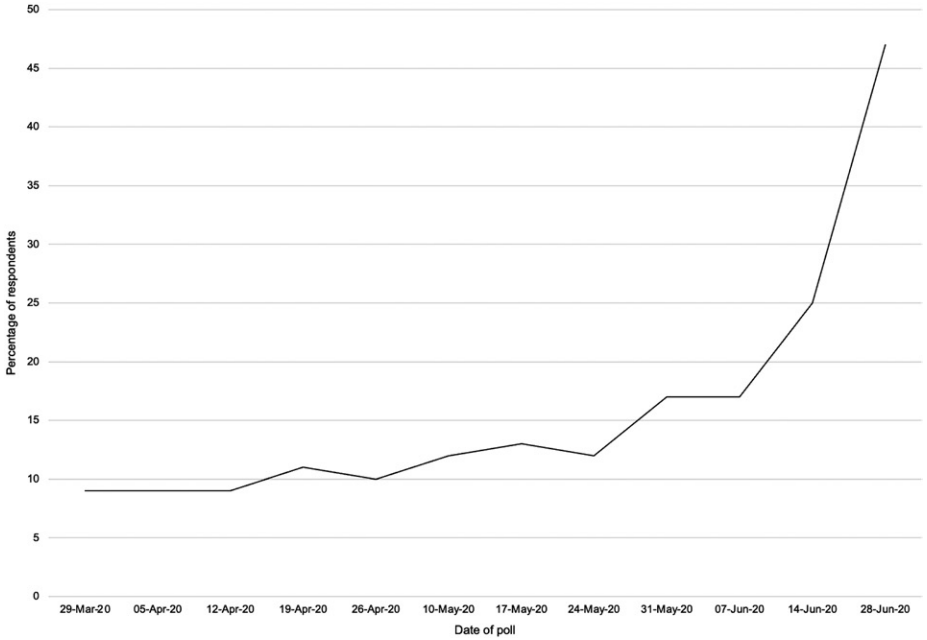
70 Elizaveta Antonova, "TsIK ob''yasnil nevozmozhnost' agitirovat' za i protiv popravok v Konstitutsiyu [The CEC explained the impossibility of campaigning for and against the amendments to the Constitution]," *RBK*, June 2, 2020, https://www.rbc.ru/politics/02/06/2020/5ed66ce69a794701b9f9e261. The formal prohibition against campaigning for or against the changes was only one of a suite of measures the authorities used to unlevel the playing field (other examples included the addition of truly popular measures in the package voted on and the use of voting fraud). That means that, even if such a prohibition had not been in place, it is unlikely that the "no" vote would have won.

71 Firoz Ahmed, Roland Hodler, and Asad Islam, "Partisan Effects of Information Campaigns in Competitive Authoritarian Elections: Evidence from Bangladesh," *The Economic Journal* 134, no. 660 (2024): 1303–30, https://doi.org/10.1093/ej/uead115.

72 CEC, "Popravki k Konstitutsii."

73 More information about the "Sputnik" polling is available here: https://ok.wciom.ru/research/vciom-sputnik.

Figure 1 Awareness of Street Information Material Regarding the Public Vote, March–June 2020



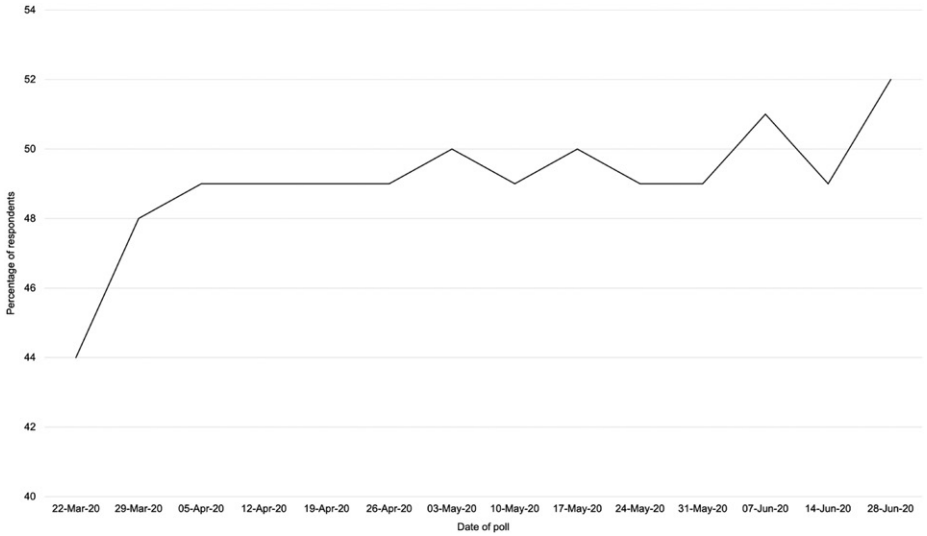
Source: VTsIOM, 2020. "Date of poll" is the end date of the respective week-long telephone poll.

are attractive for two reasons. First, they were conducted frequently. And second, they captured information beyond respondents' voting intentions, including their awareness of activities relating to the vote. Pollsters asked: "Tell me, please, have you seen or not seen billboards or information panels regarding the nationwide vote on the question of introducing changes to the Constitution of the Russian Federation?" The responses from the end of March to the end of June are shown in Figure 1. After a period of relatively low awareness, there was a clear and dramatic increase in the percentage of respondents who reported being aware of information in the month before the vote. This is consistent with a marked increase in the authorities' efforts during this period to make Russians aware of the vote and the proposed constitutional changes.[74]

Change in Popular Sentiment Available polling data also allow us to track changing levels of support for the package of proposals over time. VTsIOM pollsters asked

74 VTsIOM also asked: "Tell me, please, have you seen or not seen videos in the media or on the internet regarding the nationwide vote on the question of introducing changes to the Constitution of the Russian Federation?" In contrast to Figure 1, the level of awareness of media and online content was initially much higher than street information, but a similar rise is observed around a month before the vote.

Figure 2 Intention to Vote in Support of the Proposed Constitutional Changes



Source: VTsIOM, 2020. Note the y-axis does not start at 0. "Date of poll" is the end date of the respective week-long telephone poll.

the following question: "If you take part in the nationwide vote on the introduction of changes to the Constitution, then will you likely vote for or against the proposed changes?" Figure 2 shows responses from the end of March—once the full range of proposed amendments was public—to the end of June.[75]

Overall, the percentage of respondents saying they would vote for the package if they took part increased by eight points, from 44 to 52 percent, over this period. Net approval figures (the percentage of respondents who said they would vote for the changes minus the percentage intending to vote against) increased by three percentage points, from 17 to 20 percent. This change is modest, but in line with our expectation of a positive shift.[76]

These indicators relate to the whole package of proposed changes. But by June, the Levada Center found changing levels of support for the "zeroing" amendment as well. Although "definitely not" remained the modal response (33 percent), the percentage of

75 We are interested in responses from *after* the point the complete package of constitutional changes was made public—that is, from the first week-long poll begun after the bill's second reading in the State Duma on March 10, 2020, up to the public vote itself. In practice, that means the first "Sputnik" poll of interest is that run from March 15 to March 22, 2020. The preceding week's poll ended after the bill's second reading but began before it (March 8–15, 2020), which means that some respondents would not have known about the full range of measures included in the final package, including Putin's controversial "zeroing" amendment.

76 We cannot, of course, establish a causal connection between the regime's activities and the change in voting intentions on the basis of the evidence presented.

respondents choosing "definitely so" in support of the amendment rose from 23 to 31 percent from March to June.[77]

Voting took place over seven days. Rather than wait until all of the votes had been tallied, officials released turnout figures as voting progressed.[78] Regardless, overall approval of the package was never in doubt. In fact, copies of the new version of the Constitution were on sale in Russian bookshops before the vote took place.[79] What was less clear were the specific figures the authorities would publish concerning approval and turnout. In the end, according to the official results, the package of constitutional changes was formally approved by 78 percent of voters with a 68 percent turnout.

Post-vote survey data provide insights into the drivers of support for the package of constitutional changes. A mere 17 percent of voters explained their "yes" vote decision "first and foremost because it enabled Vladimir Putin to stay in power beyond 2024."[80] Recent research has shown that many Russian voters voted for the package of changes because of the "sugar-coating" amendments, including those enshrining conservative, so-called "traditional" values in the Constitution.[81] Indeed, the strategy adopted by the Kremlin exemplifies its broader ability to build "winning coalitions involving voters beyond their core of loyal support."[82]

The final vote count was not, of course, entirely driven by the support that was constructed through the run-up to the referendum. Some support was pre-existing. But there is also evidence of systematic manipulation, including vote fraud.[83] A report by the Russian independent election and vote monitoring organization Golos produced a damning assessment of the vote. It concluded, among other things, that early voting, which limited opportunities for oversight, had no legal basis; that the body created to carry out remote electronic (i.e., online) voting was formed illegally; that tens of millions of

77 Levada Center, "Obshcherossiyskoe Golosovanie po Popravkam v Konstitutsiyu [Nationwide Vote on Amendments to the Constitution]," July 2, 2020, https://www.levada.ru/2020/07/02/obshherossijskoe-golosovanie-po-popravkam-v-konstitutsiyu-4/.

78 Tamila Askerova, "TsIK: yavka na golosovanii po Konstitutsii v pervyy den' sostavila 9,2% [CEC: first-day turnout in the vote on the Constitution was 9.2%]," *Parlamentskaya Gazeta*, June 26, 2020, https://www.pnp.ru/politics/cik-yavka-na-golosovanii-po-konstitucii-v-pervyy-den-sostavila-92.html.

79 Elizaveta Efimovich and Natalya Galimova, "V magazinakh poyavilas' Konstitutsiya s vynesennymi na golosovanie popravkami [The Constitution with amendments put to the vote has appeared in shops]," *RBK*, June 16, 2020, https://www.rbc.ru/technology_and_media/16/06/2020/5ee794b79a79471cf17717ed.

80 Paul Chaisty and Stephen Whitefield, "Building Voting Coalitions in Electoral Authoritarian Regimes: A Case Study of the 2020 Constitutional Reform in Russia," *Post-Soviet Affairs* 39, no. 4 (2023): 279, https://doi.org/10.1080/1060586X.2023.2172945.

81 Henry E. Hale, "The Value of Values for Autocrats: Traditional Morality and Putin's 2020 Term-Limit Contravention," *Perspectives on Politics* First View (2025): 1–16, https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592725102132.

82 Chaisty and Whitefield, "Building Voting Coalitions," 273.

83 Autocrats secure the vote results they want in multiple ways. They might, for instance, use manipulation and fraud. But they might also draw on existing, genuine support for particular measures. All else equal, they have clear incentives to minimize the use of nefarious means, given that evidence of such activities can reduce regime support, even among strong regime loyalists (Ora John Reuter and David Szakonyi, "Electoral Manipulation and Regime Support: Survey Evidence from Russia," *World Politics* 73, no. 2 (2021): 275–314, https://dx.doi.org/10.1017/s0043887120000234).

people were coerced to take part in voting by employers and officials; that ballot stuffing took place; that there were many instances of multiple voting; that the secrecy of the vote was not always ensured in voting in residential areas; and that citizen observation was actively resisted by the authorities.[84] On the last point, the CEC did not invite international observers from reputable organizations, including the Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe (PACE) or the Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe (OSCE); instead, "fake observers" were brought in to praise the voting process.[85]

These manipulations made a difference. According to Sergei Shpil'kin, a Russian physicist, who rose to prominence by using statistical methods to detect evidence of vote rigging, the likely real turnout was 42 percent, with 65 percent voting in favor of the package of changes.[86] Thus, the authorities would have been able to secure a victory without fiddling with the figures. Presumably, however, the real vote tally was not sufficiently impressive, either for the central government or for the local officials charged with delivering a win.[87]

And yet, the final result was not achieved by fraud alone. As the three preceding sections of the case study show, the Russian authorities attempted to construct meaningful support among the elites and the people for a package of changes that included a controversial amendment, and popular sentiment changed in the direction desired.

Conclusion

Authoritarian referendums do not simply advertise support, real or fake, in an attempt to repress the political opposition. Nor are they an opportunity for the regime to learn about

84 Golos, "Predvaritel'noe zayavlenie po itogam obshchestvennogo nablyudeniya za khodom obshcherossiyskogo golosovaniya po izmeneniyu Konstitutsii [Preliminary statement on the results of public monitoring of the all-Russian vote on constitutional amendments]," July 2, 2020, https://www.golosinfo.org/articles/144477.

85 European Platform for Democratic Elections, "2020—Russia—'All-Russian Voting' on amendments to the Constitution of the Russian Federation," (no date), https://www.fakeobservers.org/fake-election-observers/missions/details/international-experts-at-the-2020-all-russian-voting-in-russia.html.

86 Sergei Shpil'kin, "Vot i vsya lyubov' [That's all the love]," *Novaya Gazeta*, July 2, 2020, https://novayagazeta.ru/articles/2020/07/02/86114-vot-i-vsya-lyubov.

87 Some voters treated the official results similarly skeptically. Survey results from the Levada Center suggested that the Russian "public—especially younger and working-age voters—held substantial reservations about the fairness of the referendum" (Derek S. Hutcheson and Ian McAllister, "Consolidating the Putin Regime: The 2020 Referendum on Russia's Constitutional Amendments," *Russian Politics* 6, no. 3 (2021): 375, https://doi.org/10.30965/24518921-00603004). For the original polling, see Levada Center, "Kto i Kak Golosoval za Popravki v Konstitutsiyu: Zavershayushchiy Opros [Who and How Voted for the Amendments to the Constitution: Final Poll]," August 7, 2020, https://www.levada.ru/2020/08/07/kto-i-kak-golosoval-za-popravki-v-konstitutsiyu-zavershayushhij-opros/. Perceptions of unfairness did not relate necessarily to ballot stuffing or reporting violations, but plausibly included other sources of unfairness, including the improvised nature of the vote itself and workplace mobilization. See Timothy Frye, Ora John Reuter, and David Szakonyi, "Political Machines at Work: Voter Mobilization and Electoral Subversion in the Workplace," *World Politics* 66, no. 2 (2014): 195–228, doi:10.1017/S004388711400001X.

popular sentiment or for citizens to exercise constraint over their rulers. Instead, we propose a novel argument. Focusing on public votes that are not required by the constitution, we argue that the process leading up to these voluntary referendums can be used to build support among the elite and the population for controversial initiatives. Even as the outcome of these votes might not be in question, the process of getting to that result can be crucial for the broader purposes of convincing elites to endorse, and citizens to vote for, the contentious measures in question.

The argument presented here suggests several avenues for future research. Foremost amongst them is the question of generalizability. Our empirical analysis has focused on Russia's 2020 public vote. However, this is only one instance of the 249 voluntary referendums in non-democracies between 1945 and 2020, as recorded by V-Dem. How many of these votes were used to build support to pass controversial changes?

Preliminary evidence suggests that this dynamic is widespread, including amongst post-Soviet autocracies. For example, in February 2022, Belarusian voters approved a package of constitutional changes that gave President Aleksandr Lukashenka lifetime immunity from prosecution, reset his presidential term record, and boosted the powers of an extra-parliamentary body stacked with political allies. These controversial amendments, which did not require a public vote, were accompanied by provisions that had broad popular appeal; and the referendum was promoted through flash mobs, television shows, and videos that played across public transit in the weeks leading up to the vote.[88] In Kazakhstan, President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev proposed constitutional reforms in March 2022 as a means of quelling widespread protests against economic inequality, corruption, and poor governance. Tokayev tasked a working group with drafting the changes. High-profile celebrities were recruited to publicly endorse the range of amendments, which were approved by voters in June 2022.[89]

Uzbekistan's voluntary referendum in April 2023 likewise demonstrated support-building patterns. After winning re-election in October 2021, President Shavkat Mirziyoyev pursued constitutional reforms that would extend his time in office, to be enacted through a public vote. A Constitutional Commission collected tens of thousands of suggestions from citizens, activists, labor unions, and neighborhood associations on other measures they wanted to see included. The Commission's initial draft included a controversial proposal to remove the autonomous status of the Karakalpak region, which sparked mass protests and a government response that left 21 people dead, 274 injured, and dozens more imprisoned. While this delayed the vote, it did not stop the process.

88 Fabian Burkhardt and Jan Matti Dollbaum, "Lukashenka's Constitutional Plebiscite and the Polarization of Belarusian Society," *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 56, no. 3 (2023): 98–126, https://doi.org/10.1525/cpcs.2023.1990500; Yuras Karmanau, "Belarus sheds neutral status in vote critics call rigged," *AP News*, February 28, 2022, https://apnews.com/article/russia-ukraine-europe-moscow-belarus-alexander-lukashenko-9f634ff4c13687cd9314648b6912c2b0.

89 Diana T. Kudaibergenova and Marlene Laruelle, "Making Sense of the January 2022 Protests in Kazakhstan: Failing Legitimacy, Culture of Protests, and Elite Readjustments," *Post-Soviet Affairs* 38, no. 6 (2022): 441–59, doi:10.1080/1060586X.2022.2077060; Gaziz Abishev, Bakhytzhan Kurmanov, and Zhaxylyk Sabitov, "Authoritarian Succession, Rules, and Conflicts: Tokayev's Gambit and Kazakhstan's Bloody January of 2022 (Qandy Qantar)," *Post-Soviet Affairs* 40, no. 6 (2024): 429–51, doi:10.1080/1060586X.2024.2377929.

The package that was eventually put to the public included amendments to reset Mirziyoyev's term record and increase presidential terms from five to seven years, as well as more popular measures, such as a ban on capital punishment and new human rights protections. In April 2023, the package was passed with over 90 percent support.[90]

Although these three cases relate to three former Soviet states, what we describe is likely to be a broader phenomenon. In 1984, Pakistan's President Muhammad Zia-ul-Haq called a voluntary referendum to extend martial law and legitimize his rule. Although the contentious proposal was put to a vote as a single question, the measure asked voters to weigh in simultaneously on the president's military regime (for which support was shaky) and on the role of Islam in Pakistan (a well-accepted point)—a ballot construction that "would make it difficult for anyone to advocate voting 'no' to the referendum question."[91] Zia-ul-Haq himself travelled the country lobbying voters to support the measure, which passed with overwhelming support. In sum, although a full assessment of the argument's external validity is outside the scope of this article, there are indications that the argument extends beyond the single case examined here.

Another key step toward advancing this research agenda involves establishing scope conditions for our argument. Under what conditions do autocrats choose to put controversial measures to a public vote, rather than pursuing other means of policymaking? We might expect rulers to want to build buy-in from other elites and citizens under certain conditions—for example, when there has been a recent precedent of large-scale protests against the regime. In addition, while we have focused on referendums that are organized at the discretion of the ruler, a further avenue for study concerns autocratic referendums that are constitutionally required: do rulers also work to generate support for the measures that they are required to put to the people? Also, more research is needed into how autocrats decide between different means to achieve the voting results they want: how do they decide the relative balance between the use of manipulation and investing resources into trying to convince skeptical voters? Finally, holding public votes does not come without risks in non-democracies. Although rare, authoritarian referendums sometimes result in defeat for the leadership, which can destabilize the regime, as famously seen with Augusto Pinochet's 1988 referendum in Chile. What are the causes and consequences of such failures?

More generally, as empirical work on referendums in non-democracies continues, we should encourage work that moves beyond quantitative, cross-national, large-N research designs. This article reveals the gains that can be made by qualitative analysis,

90 Eurasianet, "Where is Uzbekistan's constitutional reform heading?" May 24, 2022, https://eurasianet.org/where-is-uzbekistans-constitutional-reform-heading; Eurasianet, "Uzbekistan: Authorities close consultation on constitutional reform," August 1, 2022, https://eurasianet.org/uzbekistan-authorities-close-consultation-on-constitutional-reform; Agence France-Presse, "Uzbekistan president wins referendum on extending powers," *The Guardian*, May 1, 2023, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2023/may/01/uzbekistan-president-shavkat-mirziyoyev-wins-referendum-on-extending-powers.

91 William Borders, "Pakistani Chief Starts Campaign Tour for Referendum," *The New York Times*, December 9, 1984, https://www.nytimes.com/1984/12/09/world/pakistani-chief-starts-campaign-tour-for-referendum.html. See also William L. Richter, "Pakistan in 1984: Digging In," *Asian Survey* 25, no. 2 (1985): 145–54, https://doi.org/10.2307/2644298.

insofar as it offers sensitivity to the sequence of decisions, statements, and consultations among key actors, especially during the pre-voting phase. If we are to learn more about how referendums feature in authoritarian rule, then we need more work that examines fine-grained processes, as well as large-scale patterns.

Acknowledgements: This publication arises from research funded by the John Fell Oxford University Press Research Fund. We would like to thank Sonja Astrakhan, Tom Hazell, and Nick James for excellent research assistance. For comments on various drafts of this article, we would like to thank participants of relevant panels and sessions of the International Studies Association's 2022 Annual Convention, the American Political Science Association's 2023 Annual Meeting, the British Association for Slavonic and East European Studies' 2024 Annual Conference, and the 2026 seminar series of the Comparative Politics and Policy cluster in the University of Glasgow's School of Social and Political Sciences, as well as the anonymous reviewers and journal editors.